



Hire, collaborate, and get paid with *confidence*.

Agora is an escrow marketplace that runs inside Nimiq Pay. A job only reaches the board once its budget has been paid in and verified, so a freelancer never writes a proposal against money that might not exist. This paper describes what the product does, how the money moves, and what it does not do.

Two strangers, one of whom has to go first

Freelance work between people who have never met has a single structural problem: somebody has to move first, and whoever moves first carries all of the risk.

The freelancer who starts before payment can be left unpaid. The client who pays before delivery can be left with nothing. Platforms usually answer this by holding the money themselves and becoming the thing both sides have to trust instead. That works, and it quietly relocates the problem rather than solving it.

Agora narrows the question to something smaller and checkable: **is the money actually there, right now, and can anyone verify it.** A posting does not appear on the board until its budget has been paid in and confirmed on chain. Everything else in the product follows from that one rule.

The marketplace runs in both directions

Most boards run one way: clients post, freelancers pitch. Agora runs both ways, because the two sides look for each other differently.

Clients post jobs

A structured brief: category, service type, description, deliverables, budget, timeline and reference links. The budget is committed to escrow before the posting is published. Freelancers send proposals carrying a bid, a delivery time, a cover letter and a portfolio link.

Freelancers advertise services

A freelancer can publish what they do and what they charge, for example "I will design your logo, 300 NIM, 5 days". Clients browse these under Find workers and hire straight from one, which opens the normal posting form with the advertised terms filled in and fully editable.

WHY AN ADVERTISEMENT IS NOT A DEAL

An advertisement carries no escrow, no counterparty and no obligations. Hiring from one still creates an ordinary funded job, so every NIM that moves still moves through the same escrow. Keeping the two apart is what stops an advertisement from ever being mistaken for committed budget, which is the one promise the board makes.

Each side gets its own dashboard, navigation and default action, from one shared session. A wallet can be on both sides, and switching sides in the profile re-skins the whole dashboard without touching anything that already happened.

03

One record carries a job through its whole life

A posting, its escrow, its chat, its delivery and its dispute are the same record at different stages. That is deliberate: when a posting becomes a contract, nothing has to be copied, and the evidence a mediator eventually reads is the evidence that was there from the beginning.

STATE	WHAT IS TRUE
draft	Written, budget not yet committed. Private to the client and editable.
open	Budget paid in and verified. Live on the board, taking proposals.
locked	A proposal was accepted. Work under way, private chat open, rival bids declined.
submitted	Work handed in with delivery links, waiting on the client's review.
completed	Approved. The escrow is the freelancer's to claim.
disputed	Either party escalated. The mediator reads the deal.
settled	A mediated verdict both parties accepted split the escrow.
refunded	A mediated verdict returned the escrow to the client.
cancelled	Withdrawn before anyone was hired. Any committed budget went back.

Approving and collecting are separate events, and only one of them is a payment. A deal sits at **completed** whether or not the freelancer has claimed yet, which is why every figure in the product is read from payments rather than from state.

How money moves

Six payment types cover everything that can happen to a budget. Each one is recorded against the deal it belongs to before anything is broadcast, and no deal can hold two of the same type.

PAYMENT	DIRECTION	WHEN
fund	client to escrow	At publication. The posting goes live only once this confirms.
topup	client to escrow	When an accepted bid is above the funded budget.
claim	escrow to freelancer	After approval, when the freelancer collects.
excess_refund	escrow to client	Automatically, when an accepted bid came in under budget.
withdraw_refund	escrow to client	When a posting is withdrawn before anyone is hired.
refund	escrow to client	The client's share of a mediated settlement.

Bids that do not match the budget

A freelancer may bid above or below the posted budget, and both cases settle at the moment of acceptance rather than being left to sort out later.

- **Under budget.** The difference is refunded to the client automatically. Nothing is left stranded in escrow for a job that no longer costs that much.
- **Over budget.** Accepting asks the client to fund the difference in the same action. The deal cannot lock against money that is not there, so the board's promise still holds for the freelancer who is about to start work.

Withdrawing a job

A client can withdraw a posting right up until they hire someone, and the committed budget is returned in the same action. After a hire, the work has started against it and a dispute is the way out instead. A refund that cannot be completed leaves the posting exactly as it was: a cancelled posting whose escrow is still held would be strictly worse than a live one.

Where the money is, for each side

"How far along is this deal" and "where is the money" are different questions that drift apart constantly. Both dashboards answer the second one from the payments themselves, counting only confirmed ones, because a pending payout may still fail and a failed one moved nothing.

A CLIENT SEES	MEANING
In escrow	Their money, still held, still at stake, still recoverable by withdrawing.
Awaiting collection	Approved, so no longer theirs to withdraw, and not yet paid to anyone either.
Paid to freelancers	Left escrow and reached the person who did the work.
Returned to you	Came back, by withdrawal, by refund or by mediation.

A FREELANCER SEES	MEANING
Claimed	Collected. Money in the wallet, on deals that ended by agreement.
After mediation	Collected on a settled dispute, usually a share rather than the whole.
Waiting to claim	Approved and sitting in escrow, theirs to collect and not yet income.

These buckets never overlap and are never added together. Money that left escrow without being paid to anybody, a withdrawal for instance, is reported as exactly that rather than being folded into either side's earnings.

What protects a payment

Everything here exists because of a specific way money can be lost, not as general hardening.

ORDER

Recorded before confirmed

A payment is written down the moment it is known to be validly signed, before the chain is asked about it. The failure worth designing around is not "we could not verify it", it is "we left no trace, so they paid twice".

EVIDENCE

No refund without proof

Money is only returned against a confirmed payment, or one checked against the chain right then. The escrow wallet is pooled, so paying out a job that was never funded would hand another client's budget away.

RACES

One payout per kind, per deal

A uniqueness rule on the pair of deal and payment type means two simultaneous requests resolve to the same record. The second finds the first rather than creating a second payout.

CEILING

A rolling outflow limit

Payouts stop and alert rather than continuing past a 24 hour threshold. Either the platform grew or something is draining it, and both want a person looking within the hour.

DESTINATION

Never from the request

Where a payout goes is read from the database, from the address that party authenticated with. Nothing a caller sends can influence who gets paid.

RECONCILIATION

Balance against obligations

A health check compares what the escrow wallet actually holds against what the records say is owed. A shortfall is the alarm; stuck payouts are counted alongside it.

ON RETRIES

A failed request must never become a second real payment. When a payment cannot be confirmed, the product resumes the one already on file rather than asking the wallet to sign again, and says so in words that cannot be mistaken for "send it again".

07

Disputes, and what the AI is allowed to do

Either party can escalate a deal that is under way or submitted. The mediator, Gemini 3.6 Flash with a schema enforced server side, reads the original requirements and deliverables, the delivery timeline with lateness flagged, the submitted work, and the recent conversation from the deal's own chat.

It returns one of `release`, `refund`, `partial_refund` or `escalate`, and on every verdict a percentage: the share it judges the freelancer to have earned.

THE VERDICT IS A RECOMMENDATION

It moves nothing. One party accepting records their acceptance; the second acceptance is what triggers the payout, splitting the escrow in whole units so the two sides sum to the total exactly. Either party can reject, which ends that verdict without moving money and leaves the case open for fresh evidence. A verdict of `escalate` cannot be accepted at all, because the mediator declined to call it.

Neither the model nor the platform can move money on its own. That is the honest answer to "you let an AI decide who gets paid", and a case that stays deadlocked can be referred to a human mediator whose ruling is binding and recorded against their name.

Because the chat opens at selection and is retained as evidence, the record a mediator reads is the one both parties built while the work was happening, not a summary written afterwards by whoever complained first.

08

Reputation that follows the wallet

Both sides carry a record, because a client who disputes everything is as much a risk as a freelancer who delivers nothing. Every settled deal updates it.

- **Trust score**, out of 100, derived from engagements, completions and dispute rate.
- **Completion rate**, how much of what was started was finished.
- **Dispute rate**, alongside average delivery time in days.

A proposal arrives carrying that record and a portfolio link, so a stranger arrives with a track record rather than a claim. A mediated split is recorded as a dispute on both sides and is never counted as a completion for either.

09

What running on NimiQ actually buys

Agora is a Mini App: it opens inside NimiQ Pay, where the wallet is already connected and every sensitive action raises NimiQ Pay's own confirmation dialog.

- **No passwords and no signup form.** Signing in is signing a message. Agora never sees a private key or a seed phrase.
- **Payments are ordinary transfers** the payer's own wallet signs, which means the signed transaction is itself evidence of who paid whom how much.
- **Verification comes in two parts.** The signed transaction is decoded to read the payer, the destination and the amount before the network has seen it, then the chain's own copy

settles whether it landed. A signature proves intent; only the chain proves arrival.

- **Amounts settle in luna**, the smallest unit, where one NIM is 100,000 luna. Splits are computed in whole luna so a mediated division can neither invent money nor strand a fraction of it.
- **Wrong chain is caught loudly**. A payment signed for a different network is rejected with that named as the cause, rather than silently never being found.

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Limits, stated plainly

A document that only lists strengths is marketing. These are the things a reader should know before trusting the product with money.

The escrow is custodial today

Budgets are held in a single Agora-controlled NimiQ account, and payouts are signed by Agora. Nothing on chain enforces a mediated verdict: the enforcement is the rules described in this paper. The account is reconciled against outstanding obligations continuously, and every payout is bounded by the controls in section 06, but a reader should understand that this is custody, not a trustless contract.

Per deal hash contracts are not yet created on chain

The release secret and its hash are minted and recorded for every funded job, and approval is what reveals the secret to the freelancer. The missing piece is the contract itself: the NimiQ Pay Mini App SDK exposes account listing, message signing, consensus and block height, and ordinary transfers, but no method for signing a contract creation. Until that exists, the hash lock is a recorded commitment rather than an on chain one, and closing that gap is the single largest item on the roadmap.

Smaller boundaries

- Attachments and deliveries are links, not hosted uploads.
- Work is approved as a whole. There is no milestone-by-milestone release.
- The mediator reads the recent chat rather than an unbounded history.
- A withdrawal cannot be completed while the network cannot be reached, by design: the posting is left untouched rather than guessing in either direction.

THE ONE PROMISE

Everything above exists to keep a single sentence true: if a job is on the board, its budget has already been paid in and verified. A freelancer reading it can start work knowing the money is there, and a client can see exactly where theirs is at every moment after that.

